

Why Technical Leaders Get Worse Results from Experts (And What to Change)

****Quick Bridge:**** If you are technically skilled, you probably arrive at solutions faster than most people in the room. That speed is an asset. But when you lead with the answer instead of the problem, you are quietly undermining every expert you work with. Here is what the research shows — and what to do instead.

The Mistake Technically Skilled Leaders Make Most Often

There is a pattern I see repeatedly in technically strong leaders. They get hired because they can analyze a situation quickly and identify the right solution. That capability is real and valuable.

But the same skill creates a specific problem when they interact with experts — whether that is a service professional, a project manager, a specialist on their team, or anyone else who holds deep domain knowledge in an area that is not theirs.

The pattern: they arrive at the solution before the conversation starts, then use the conversation to deliver it.

The result: the expert feels bypassed, delivers compliance instead of expertise, and the outcome is worse than it would have been if the leader had just led with the problem.

A Real Example: The Service Counter

I had an engineer friend who drove a Mini Cooper. Same dealership I used. I always left satisfied. He complained constantly about the service.

We ended up there at the same time one afternoon. I watched what happened.

He had done his research. He knew exactly what he thought was wrong, how it needed to be fixed, and how long it should take. He told the service advisor all of it at the counter.

The service advisor had spent years working on Mini Coopers. He knew that car's common failure points better than any forum my friend had read. Getting a list of instructions from a customer, rather than a request to solve a problem, frustrated him visibly. My friend got indifferent service.

I had done the same research. But when I got to the counter I said four words: "Will you figure it out?"

He diagnosed the car. Explained what he found. I could verify his reasoning because I had done my homework. I left happy.

Same information. Different result. The only thing that changed was what I did with the information before I opened my mouth.

What the Research Says About Autonomy and Expert Performance

This is not just intuition. Research on leader autonomy support — the degree to which leaders give employees choice, acknowledge their perspectives, and minimize controlling pressure — consistently shows meaningful effects on performance.

A 2018 meta-analytic review published in PLOS ONE (Slemp et al.) examined data across multiple studies and found that leader autonomy support was significantly associated with higher task performance, greater job satisfaction, and stronger organizational commitment among employees. When people are given the opportunity to apply their own judgment rather than execute someone else's instructions, they perform better and care more about the outcome.

[Source: Slemp et al., 2018 — Leader autonomy support in the workplace: A meta-analytic review. PLOS ONE / PMC: <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6133074/>]

The research maps directly onto what I saw at the service counter: my friend's approach removed the advisor's autonomy. Mine preserved it. The difference in outcome was not a coincidence.

How It Shows Up in Technical Teams

The Mini Cooper example is vivid, but the same dynamic plays out inside organizations every day.

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A game engineer notices the project is running behind. She needs more time. So she goes to the project manager and says: "You need to move the date by two weeks. We are late."

The project manager pushes back. Asks questions. The engineer feels dismissed.

From the PM's perspective: protecting the timeline is her job. Managing downstream commitments is her job. When someone walks in and issues a directive — "move the date" — she has to understand the why, the scope of impact, and whether alternatives exist. She is not obstructing. She is doing her job with incomplete information.

The engineer gave her a solution. She needed a situation report.

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A senior engineer notices a bug that has been causing customer complaints. She goes to the developer responsible and says: "You need to fix this by adding a session token check at line 47 and building a fallback handler."

The developer now has instructions. He implements them. But the root cause was actually two layers deeper, and the fix the engineer specified creates a new edge case that takes three more days to untangle.

If the engineer had said "Customers are hitting an error when they refresh mid-session. It needs to be solid before launch. Can you dig into what is causing it?" — the developer applies his full knowledge of the system. He finds the deeper cause. The fix is cleaner.

Why the Fastest Thinkers Are Most at Risk

Technically strong leaders often struggle with this more than generalist leaders. There are two reasons.

****First, speed.**** When you can diagnose quickly, the solution arrives in your mind before most people in the room have even finished processing the problem. Sharing that solution feels natural. It also feels efficient — why slow the conversation down to describe what you already understand?

****Second, identity.**** For many technically skilled people, finding the answer is the core of how they add value. Holding back the answer can feel like withholding contribution. It can even feel like uncertainty or lack of confidence.

Both of those feelings are wrong. Describing the problem is not slowing down — it is what makes the expert's best work possible. And it requires confidence, not less of it, to resist the urge to hand over the answer.

[For more on why technical leaders struggle to let go, see: MIT Sloan — The Delegation Dilemma: <https://executive.mit.edu/blog/the-delegation-dilemma-why-leaders-struggle-to-let-go.html>]

What the Expert Loses When You Over-Direct

When you deliver a solution instead of a problem, the expert loses several things at once.

****They lose ownership.**** If the solution is yours, the outcome is yours. They are executing your plan. When something goes wrong — and it sometimes will — the accountability structure is muddy. They followed your instructions.

****They lose the chance to apply what they actually know.**** Every domain expert carries information that is not in any forum, not in any brief you prepared, not in any meeting you attended. That knowledge only comes out when they are asked to solve the problem, not execute the fix.

****They lose motivation.**** Autonomy is one of the most consistent predictors of intrinsic motivation at work. Research from the field of self-determination theory has documented this across industries and roles for decades. When you remove someone's autonomy over how they solve a problem, you reduce their investment in solving it well. [See also: PMC — Leaders' behaviors and employees' feedback-seeking behavior: <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC5461250/>]

The cumulative effect is a team or a professional relationship where the expert stops thinking. They comply. And the cost of that shows up slowly, in ways that are hard to trace back to the cause.

The Practical Shift: Three Language Changes

This does not require a personality overhaul. It requires one habit: separating the information from the instruction.

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Before: "The authentication module needs to be refactored — start with the token handling layer." After: "Users are getting logged out unexpectedly after about 15 minutes. It needs to be reliable and I want to understand what is causing it."

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Before: "Move the deadline. We need two more weeks." After: "We are running behind by two weeks and here is the breakdown. I wanted you to have this information."

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This is the hardest one for fast thinkers. Ask first. "What do you think is causing this?" Then listen. Then bring your hypothesis to verify or challenge what they said. You will be right sometimes. And sometimes you will learn something that changes everything.

Applying This Monday

Before your next conversation with someone whose expertise is not yours, do this:

Write down what you are about to say. Then ask: am I describing a problem, or giving a solution?

If you are giving a solution, rewrite it as a problem statement. Describe what is happening, what the impact is, and what success looks like. Then stop. Let the expert do their job.

You can still verify. You can still push back if the diagnosis does not make sense. But you lead with the problem. Every time.

Have you seen this play out on your team — someone over-directing an expert and getting worse results? What changed it?

You are great at the work. Let us make you impossible to ignore.

If you are looking for help with how you communicate across teams and disciplines, consider reaching out.

<https://www.jessestaffordcoaching.com>

****Impact Labels:**** Technical visibility, Peer leadership